Lipid profiles of Yanomamo Indians of Brazil.

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To determine serum lipid levels and their correlates in one of the world's most isolated populations, 62 adult Yanomamo Indians from the Amazonian rain forest were examined. After measurement of body weight and height, and estimation of age, casual blood samples were obtained. Estimated age ranged from 20 to 68 years, with men averaging 37 and women 35 years. Mean serum total cholesterol was very low among both men (123 mg/dl) and women (142 mg/dl) compared with western samples, whereas triglycerides--112 and 110 mg/dl, respectively--were lower among men and slightly higher among women than for U.S. men and women. Yanomamo women had significantly higher total cholesterol (P = 0.02) and body mass index (BMI) (P = 0.05) than men. HDL-cholesterol (P = 0.08) and LDL-cholesterol (P = 0.21) were also somewhat higher among women. Multivariate regression analysis indicated that estimated age was independently related to cholesterol in both sexes, while BMI was of borderline significance. The very low serum lipid levels in this isolated population are apparently attributable mainly to their largely vegetarian diet, low in fats and cholesterol and high in fiber, with concomitant high physical activity associated with low BMI.